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Mumbai struggles with even 10% of 2005 deluge

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MUMBAI: A decade has passed since the 26/7 deluge but many citizens and experts said very little has been learned by the authorities. Mumbai received 944.2 mm of rainfall, which crippled the city on July 26, 2005, but even less than 10% of this rain received in the city and suburbs now causes flooding at several low-lying areas. Experts wondered what lessons the authorities have learned since then.

In the 2005 deluge, more than 500 people were killed in Mumbai, Thane, Navi Mumbai and the Konkan region. Most deaths —273—were reported from Mumbai. Infrastructure losses were estimated at Rs 1,000 crore, livestock at Rs 100 crore, housing at Rs 300 crore and crops at Rs 600 crore after the deluge.
This year, on July 20-21, the suburbs received only 61mm of rain, but many spots in the city were flooded and Central Railway services came to a standstill for 20 minutes.

Bandra resident and AGNI trustee Shyama Kulkarni said the civic authorities must come up with a permanent solution when they know there are so many low-lying areas. “Every year we continue to get news about how spots like the Milan subway and Hindmata have got flooded following a downpour. Why is there no permanent solution in place even a decade later? In fact, work on cleaning nullahs begins late, and it is done in a hurry, every year. The Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation has such an enormous budget and no excuses made would ever be able to justify why measures are not in place or the work is not done,” said Kulkarni.
Corporators said the administration lacked seriousness in resolving civic issues on the ground. “Mumbai is the financial capital and it’s unfair to not provide quality services. One cannot keep blaming nature all the time and the fact that Mumbai is an island city. It is definitely not rocket science to resolve flooding issues at spots which are chronic,” said Asif Zakaria, Congress corporator from Bandra.

“There still are areas like Jay Bharat in Old Khar which get flooded. These got flooded on July 26, 2005, and today the situation there is still the same,” Zakaria added.

However, experts blamed citizens too for flooding which the city witnesses with any downpour for a few hours. When heavy rain had crippled Mumbai on June 19 this year, civic officials claimed that places like the Irla nullah had bedding and wooden tables dumped into it.

“Tonnes of plastic and thermocol are thrown into nullahs, clogging them completely. People in the city act so ignorant that until laws are applied strictly, it is very unlikely that anything will change. People will keep their own backyards clean but don’t mind dumping plastic in other areas,” said Stalin Dayanand of the NGO Vanashakti. However, he added how with little or no soil left on account of everything in Mumbai today having been concretized, there is very little space that rain water finds to percolate.

Khar resident Surindra Khubchandani, who lives at Jay Bharat Society, said water took hours to recede from his area with barely any rain on Tuesday. “Our underground water tanks get contaminated due to the flood water that accumulates. The cars in our building also get damaged due to the flooding,” said Khubchandani.